

Effectual Calling

doc-effectual-calling

Soteriology · Calling · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

God calls His people through the Word and Spirit: outwardly through preaching and inwardly so that the call is effective unto salvation in those who respond by faith.

In plain language

The words for calling do not all behave the same way, and that is exactly why readers divide. The verb for call ('to call', καλέω, kaleo) appears about one hundred forty times across the New Testament and clearly carries two senses: sometimes it simply means naming or summoning, and sometimes it means a saving call from God. In Romans 8:30 the verb sits in a tight chain where the same group that God foreknew and predestined is called, then justified, then glorified, with no one dropping out, which points to a calling that actually reaches the people it names and carries them through to glory. But the adjective form of the same word group ('called', κλητός, kletos) cuts both ways. In Romans 8:28 and First Corinthians 1:24 the called are a defined group joined to God's purpose, the very ones for whom the preached Christ is power and wisdom. Yet in Matthew 22:14 the same adjective is placed in plain contrast, many are called but few are chosen ('chosen', ἐκλεκτός, eklektos), so there the called are a wider crowd than the saved, and the word marks a broad invitation that does not by itself secure salvation. The noun form ('calling', κλήσις, klesis), holy calling, by contrast always means the saving call. So the single vocabulary supplies two patterns, an effective call that reaches its recipients and a broad call that does not, and nothing in the words themselves ranks the two for the salvation texts. John 6:44-45 brings in a different word, to draw ('to draw', ἐλκύω, helkuo), plus the language of being taught by God ('taught', διδάκτός, didaktos), saying no one can come unless the Father draws him and the drawn one is raised at the last day, which describes an inward enabling. But a complicating verse, John 12:32, uses that same drawing word and says the lifted-up Christ draws all. The lexical evidence strongly supports both an outward proclaimed call and an inward divine drawing, but it does not by itself settle whether the calling word always means the effective sense, so the pattern is best read as materially disputed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0191	ἀκούω	akouō	to hear	
G1318	διδάκτός	didaktos	taught	2
G1344	δικαιώω	dikaioo	to justify	36
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	
G1410	δύναμαι	dunamai	be able	211
G1411	δύναμις	dunamis	power	

G1588	ἐκλεκτός	eklektos	select	22
G1670	ἐλκύω	helkuo	to draw/persuade	8
G2098	εὐαγγέλιον	euangelion	gospel	77
G2453	Ἰουδαῖος	Ioudaios	Jew	
G2564	καλέω	kaleo	to call	148
G2784	κηρύσσω	kerusso	to preach	64
G2821	κλῆσις	klesis	calling	11
G2822	κλητός	kletos	called	10
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	19
G3129	μανθάνω	manthano	to learn	25
G4309	προορίζω	proorizo	to predestine	6

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The calling word group is genuinely polysemous (carries multiple meanings) in the queried canon, and that polysemy is the whole dispute. The verb 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo, Strong's G2564, 148 tokens across 140 verses) carries a naming or summoning sense (for example naming a child in Luke 1:13) and a saving sense (Romans 8:30, Romans 9:24, 1 Corinthians 1:9, 2 Thessalonians 2:14, 2 Timothy 1:9, 1 Peter 2:9). The adjective 'called' (κλητός, kletos, Strong's G2822, 10 verses) does the same: in Matthew 22:14 the 'called ones' (κλητοί, kletoi) are explicitly set against the 'chosen ones' (ἐκλεκτοί, eklektoi, from Strong's G1588) by the contrastive particle 'but' (δέ, de), so there the called are a broad summoned group that is not coextensive with the saved, while in Romans 8:28 the 'called ones' (κλητοί, kletoi) are called 'according to purpose' (κατὰ πρόθεσιν, kata prothesin) and in 1 Corinthians 1:24 they are the subset for whom Christ is power and wisdom. The noun 'calling' (κλῆσις, klesis, Strong's G2821, 11 verses) is by contrast uniformly the saving or heavenly calling. In Romans 8:30 the verb sits in an unbroken 'whom...these' (οὓς...τούτους, hous...toutous) chain with no attrition of referent, justified ('to declare righteous', δικάιω, dikaioo, Strong's G1344) and glorified, which reads as effective (actually accomplishing what it names), but the same lexeme (the same dictionary word) in Matthew 22:14 reads as a broad invitation, so the words alone do not rank the two senses for the saving texts.

Scripture

Rom.8.30 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2564 καλέω, G1344 δικάιω

Reasoning. The simple past form 'he called' (aorist, a completed past action; ἐκάλεσεν, ekalesen, from kaleo, Strong's G2564) stands inside a tightly linked chain in which the same relative group, marked by 'whom' (οὓς, hous) and resumed by 'these' (τούτους, toutous), is foreknown, predestined, called, declared righteous ('justified', ἐδικαίωσεν, edikaiosen, from dikaioo, Strong's G1344), and glorified. The referent does not shrink at any link, so within this construction the calling describes an act that reaches its named recipients all the way to glory. In context this reads as an effective, salvation-attaining sense of the verb, though that force comes from the unbroken pronoun chain, not from the bare lexeme (the dictionary word taken alone).

Rom.8.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2822 κλητός

Reasoning. Those who love God are described as 'called ones according to purpose' (κλητοῖς κατὰ πρόθεσιν, kletois kata prothesin, from kletos, Strong's G2822), the called according to His purpose. Here the adjective 'called' (κλητός, kletos) marks a defined group tied to God's purpose, the same group that the following verse predestines and calls, so in this clause 'called' (κλητός, kletos) carries the effective sense (the kind of calling that actually accomplishes what it names) of a calling rooted in divine purpose rather than a bare invitation. It supplies the effective pole of the adjective's range.

Matt.22.14 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2822 κλητός, G1588 ἐκλεκτός

Reasoning. Many are 'called ones' (κλητοί, kletoi, from kletos, Strong's G2822) but few are 'chosen ones' (ἐκλεκτοί, eklektoi, from eklektos, Strong's G1588), with the two adjectives set in direct contrast by 'but' (δέ, de). Here the called are explicitly a broader group than the chosen, so 'called' (κλητός, kletos) denotes a summons that does not by itself secure final salvation for all it names. This is the decisive counter-pattern: the very same adjective that reads as effective in Romans 8:28 reads as a non-saving broad invitation here, which the lexeme (the bare dictionary word) alone cannot reconcile.

1Cor.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία

Reasoning. The simple past passive form 'you were called' (aorist passive, a completed past action received by the subject; ἐκλήθητε, eklethete, from kaleo, Strong's G2564) states that the readers were called by the faithful God into 'fellowship' (κοινωνία, koinonia, Strong's G2842) with His Son. The verb is grounded in God's faithfulness, 'faithful is God' (πιστός ὁ θεός, pistos ho theos), and aims at a saving relationship, but the term itself does not specify an inward irresistible mode and could describe the summons that brings into fellowship. It supports a calling purposed unto salvation without by itself encoding inward efficacy.

1Cor.1.23 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2784 κηρύσσω, G2453 Ἰουδαῖος

Reasoning. The present tense 'we proclaim' (present indicative, an ongoing, simple statement of fact; κηρύσσομεν, kerussomen, from kerusso 'to preach', Strong's G2784) describes the outward act of preaching a crucified Christ, received as stumbling-block to Jews and folly to Gentiles. This fixes the outward, proclaimed dimension as universal in audience yet not uniform in effect, and supplies the contrast against which the called of the next verse are distinguished.

1Cor.1.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2822 κλητός, G1411 δύναμις

Reasoning. To the very ones called, 'to them, the called ones themselves' (αὐτοῖς τοῖς κλητοῖς, autois tois kletois, from kletos, Strong's G2822), both Jews and Greeks, the same preached Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God. The adjective marks out a subset for whom the identical proclamation is effective, set against those of verse 23 for whom it is offense and folly. This contrast between the called and the unresponsive hearers supports a distinction between an outward call and an effective call, and here 'called' (κλητός, kletos) sits at its effective pole (the meaning where the calling actually accomplishes what it names).

2Thess.2.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2098 εὐαγγέλιον, G1391 δόξα

Reasoning. God called (the simple past 'he called', ἐκάλεσεν, ekalesen, from kaleo, Strong's G2564) the readers through our gospel, 'through the gospel' (διὰ τοῦ εὐαγγελίου, dia tou euangelion, from euangelion, Strong's G2098), aiming at the obtaining of the 'glory' (δόξα, doxa, Strong's G1391) of the Lord Jesus Christ. The verb is explicitly mediated by gospel proclamation, joining the outward instrument and the saving goal in one clause. It shows the call operating through the preached word toward salvation, while the verb itself does not isolate an inward dimension.

2Tim.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2564 καλέω, G2821 κλήσις

Reasoning. God called us, 'having called' (καλέσαντος, kalesantos, from kaleo, Strong's G2564), with a holy calling, 'with a holy calling' (κλήσει ἁγία, klesai hagia, from klesis, Strong's G2821), not according to our works but according to His own purpose, 'not according to our works but according to His own purpose' (οὐ κατὰ τὰ ἔργα ἡμῶν ἀλλὰ κατὰ ἰδίαν πρόθεσιν, ou kata ta erga hemon alla kata idian prothesin). The verb and its cognate noun (a noun built from the same root) are paired for emphasis and the calling is explicitly grounded in divine purpose and severed from human works, so in this clause both the verb and the noun sit at the effective, purpose-rooted pole of the word group.

1Pet.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2564 καλέω, G1588 ἐκλεκτός

Reasoning. The readers are a chosen race, 'a chosen race' (γένος ἐκλεκτόν, genos eklekton, from eklektos, Strong's G1588), of the one who called them, 'the one having called' (καλέσαντος, kalesantos, from kaleo, Strong's G2564), out of darkness into His marvelous light. The calling and the election sit in the same clause and describe the same accomplished transfer from darkness to light, so here the verb 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo) is co-located with election in an effective, already-realized sense.

John.6.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1670 ἐλκύω, G1410 δύναμαι

Reasoning. No one is able ('he is able', present indicative, ongoing simple statement of fact; δύναται, dunatai, from dunamai, Strong's G1410) to come to Christ unless the Father who sent Him draws (subjunctive form 'he might draw', ἐλκύσῃ, helkuse, from helkuo 'to drag or draw', Strong's G1670) him, and that same one Christ will raise up at the last day. The negated 'to be able' (δύναμαι, dunamai) asserts an inability removed only by the Father's drawing, and the resurrection clause shows the drawn one is the same one finally raised. This describes an inward enabling effective unto final salvation, but it uses 'to draw' (ἐλκύω, helkuo), not the 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo) stem, so it bears on enablement rather than on the meaning of calling itself.

John.6.45 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1318 διδάκτός, G3129 μανθάνω

Reasoning. Citing the prophets, everyone who has heard from the Father and learned ('having learned', participle form; μαθὼν, mathon, from manthano 'to learn', Strong's G3129) comes to Christ, and all shall be taught of God, 'taught ones of God' (διδάκτοι θεοῦ, didaktoi theou, from didaktos 'taught', Strong's G1318). The participial chain (a string of verbal-adjective forms) of hearing, learning, and coming presents an inward divine teaching that issues in coming to Christ. Whether 'all' (πᾶς, pas), everyone, is coextensive with the elect or describes the general scope of divine teaching is the disputed point, but the verse plainly couples inward instruction with coming.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.8.30	Rom.8.28	openbible	51

Rom.8.30	Rev.17.14	openbible	51
Rom.8.30	1Pet.2.9	openbible	24
Rom.8.30	1Cor.1.9	openbible	14
Matt.22.14	Matt.20.16	openbible	26
Matt.22.14	Rev.17.14	openbible	36
Matt.22.14	2Pet.1.10	openbible	43
John.6.44	John.6.65	openbible	74
John.6.44	John.12.32	openbible	20
1Cor.1.24	1Cor.1.30	tsk	1
1Cor.1.9	1Cor.10.13	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Matt.22.14 · addressed

Matthew 22:14 places 'called ones' (κλητοί, kletoi, from kletos, Strong's G2822) and 'chosen ones' (ἐκλεκτοί, eklektoi, from eklektos, Strong's G1588) in direct contrast, many called but few chosen, so here the called are a wider group than the saved and the adjective denotes a non-effective broad invitation. The same adjective reads as effective in Romans 8:28 and 1 Corinthians 1:24, and in Revelation 17:14, OpenBible votes 36, 'called and chosen ones' (κλητοὶ καὶ ἐκλεκτοί, kletoi kai eklektoi) appear together describing the Lamb's saved company. The tension is genuine and grammatical: the lexeme (the dictionary word) 'called' (κλητός, kletos) carries both a broad-invitation sense and a saving sense in the same corpus, and nothing in the word itself ranks them, which is the root of the dispute over whether the saving call is always effective.

John.12.32 · addressed

John 12:32, OpenBible votes 20 from John 6:44, uses the same verb 'to draw' (ἐλκύω, helkuo, Strong's G1670) but adds 'all' (πάντας, pantas), where the lifted-up Christ draws all to Himself. This broadens the drawing to all without distinction, which complicates reading 'to draw' (ἐλκύω, helkuo) in John 6:44 as denoting only an effective drawing of a fixed group. The same verb describes a drawing tied to certain resurrection in John 6:44 and a drawing of all in John 12:32, so the lexeme (the dictionary word taken alone) cannot settle the effective versus universal scope of the drawing.

John.6.65 · addressed

John 6:65, OpenBible votes 74 from John 6:44, restates that no one can come unless it is granted by the Father, reinforcing the inability-and-enablement structure of 6:44. This supports the inward, divinely granted dimension of coming to Christ, but like 6:44 it uses coming and granting language rather than the 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo) stem, so it bears on enablement more than on the meaning of calling per se.

1Cor.10.13 · unaddressed

The TSK (Treasury of Scripture Knowledge cross-reference set) link from 1 Corinthians 1:9 to 1 Corinthians 10:13 turns on the shared term 'faithful' (πιστός, pistos), the faithful God, rather than on calling vocabulary, so it speaks to divine faithfulness in providing a way of escape, not to whether the call is effective. It is left unresolved because it does not advance the calling distinction one way or the other and its connection is lexically tangential to the word group under study.

Concordance traversed

G2564, G2822, G2821, G1588, G1670, G1318, G4309, G1344, G1410, G2098, G2784, G2842, G3129, G0191

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

All anchor verses lie outside the ingested ECM apparatus window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), which covers only 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so no CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a computational tool for evaluating manuscript relationships) apparatus data applies and the flag 'not in ECM scope' was reported true in the bundle. The editorial marks visible in the source text at 2 Thessalonians 2:14 and John 6:44-45 concern wording, not the calling vocabulary, and do not bear on whether the call is effective. The verdict turns on lexical semantics (the meanings of words), the dual sense of 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo) and 'called' (κλητός, kletos), and is robust across plausible variant readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. effectual_calling, general_call_resistible

analogia scripturae invoked

effectual_calling: affirms · On this reading the saving call in the soteriological (salvation-related) texts is the inwardly effective sense of the word group. Romans 8:30 puts 'he called' (ἐκάλεσεν, ekalesen, from kaleo, Strong's G2564) in an unbroken pronoun chain where every called person is also justified and glorified, with no attrition. Romans 8:28 and 1 Corinthians 1:24 use 'called' (κλητός, kletos, Strong's G2822) for a purpose-rooted subset, 2 Timothy 1:9 grounds the calling in God's purpose and not works, 1 Peter 2:9 pairs the verb with election, and John 6:44-45 adds an inward drawing ('to draw', ἐλκύω, helkuo) and teaching ('taught', διδάκτος, didaktos) that issues in coming. Taken together the call that names a person is the call that brings that person all the way home, distinct from the outward preaching that meets stumbling and folly.

general_call_resistible: partially_affirms · On this reading 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo) and 'called' (κλητός, kletos) primarily name the gospel summons that goes out through preaching, 1 Corinthians 1:9 and 2 Thessalonians 2:14 tying the call directly to the proclaimed word, and Matthew 22:14 showing that the called, 'called ones' (κλητοί, kletoi), are explicitly a wider group than the chosen, 'chosen ones' (ἐκλεκτοί, eklektoi). The summons is genuine and universal in scope and becomes effective only in those who respond by faith, with John 12:32 drawing all without distinction. On this lens the efficacy is located in the response and in distinct drawing language, so the calling word itself does not denote an irresistible inward act, and the Romans 8:30 chain describes the realized history of those who do believe rather than defining the lexeme (the dictionary word).

The question stem already builds in the distinction between an outward call and an inwardly effective call. Applying 'the analogy of Scripture' (analogia scripturae, the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture) across the queried anchors yields strong support for divine inward enablement, John 6:44-45, and for a called subset within the hearing audience, 1 Corinthians 1:23-24, but the same dictionary form 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo) is also the gospel summons and the adjective 'called' (κλητός, kletos) is the broad invitation in Matthew 22:14, so the identical vocabulary supports both lenses. Progressive revelation (the principle that God's revelation unfolds over time across the canon) is not load-bearing since all anchors are New Testament.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. God calls people to Himself through the proclaimed word, and Scripture also speaks of an inward divine drawing and teaching that accompanies the call. Whether the words for calling by themselves denote an inwardly effective act ('to call', καλέω, kaleo; 'called', κλητός, kletos; 'calling', κλήσις, klesis), or whether the call is a general summons made effective by the hearer's faith response, is the question to be tested.

The phrase 'the call is effective unto salvation in those who respond by faith' embeds a specific taxonomy (a category framework) distinguishing an effective inward call from a general outward call. That distinction is a theological category, not a lexical given (it is not built into the dictionary meaning of the words themselves). The queried data shows the verb 'to call' (καλέω, kaleo, Strong's G2564) used both for naming or summoning and for a saving calling, and the adjective 'called' (κλητός, kletos, Strong's G2822) used both for the broad invitation, Matthew 22:14, and for a purpose-rooted saved subset, Romans 8:28. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form (a rephrasing that strips out the contested category labels) separates the lexical observation, outward proclamation plus inward drawing and teaching language, from the contested category label. VERDICT-CHANGED: no, the verdict was kept at disputed because the deeper canon distribution confirms the polysemy (the multiple-meaning pattern) rather than resolving it.

Citations

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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.8.30
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.22.14
morphology	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2564
morphology	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2822
morphology	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2821
morphology	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1588
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.1.9
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Flags

lexically-disputed · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent